

Work Your Brain Cells with Strategy Games on GNU/Linux

Are you ready to accept the double-barrelled challenge of acquiring hard-to-get natural resources and confronting enemies on the rampage, while in a race against time?

GNU/Linux is not all work and no play. Not content with the creation of work software, the Free Software community has produced a rich selection of games, quite a few of which are as entertaining as their proprietary cousins.

Strategy games are perhaps the most imaginative and fun in the whole gaming repertoire. So are you new to strategy gaming? Fellow FOSS fan, just visualise chessmen on the board. Done? Now endow the chessmen with human life or magical powers. Put them into fantasy or historic story-lines. What you get is a strategy game. Just add a computer, and you get graphical effects to rival your own fertile imagination.

Allow such joys to unfold (after work) as you become a magician and put all comers to flame and sword in *Glest*. Populate the wild, wild American West and win independence from the British in *FreeCol*. Take the path of expansion and forge alliances or make war in *FreeCiv*. If peace, not war, gives you enjoyment, become an urban planner and tackle pollution to render your city idyllic, in *LinCity*. Here is entertainment that engages your capabilities to strategise. The best part is that all these brilliant games are free/libre software!

Pit magic against technology in *Glest*

Set in a medieval era, *Glest* pits the minions of magic against those of technology. Whichever side you take (the other is played by the computer, or you could play with others over the Web), you'll stockpile gold, wood and stone, maintain stocks of grain at all times, and raise a host of foot soldiers and cavalry, with reserves of armour and even flying contraptions, demons and dragons. In *Glest*, the rhythm is: when you are not fighting, build fighters. Finishing off opponents is the only objective (does it have to be?).

As for battles, tactically position individual soldiers or groups of them. Reconnoitre locations, lay ambush, block paths, organise battlefronts and cripple your enemy in subsequent skirmishes. In the meanwhile, try and grow your

force as fast as you can, though casualties will pile up. Choose armoured or mounted fighters over unarmed foot soldiers. *Glest* is just complex enough to be enjoyable. Certain fighting units require certain buildings to function. These buildings need natural resources. Natural resources need miners. But hey, soldiers are needed, too, to defend the fort during mining. And you'll always find yourself short of time in this arms race. So, you have multiple pressures on resources, personnel and time. How do you balance infrastructure construction with army recruitment? That is where strategic thinking is called for. The capability to quickly build a large army and to strategise in battle should lead to a win. Mind you, the *Glest* AI is designed to be hard to beat. You'll need to browse the *Glest* manual on [wikia](#) (see below) for tips and tricks.

Unlike turn-based strategy games, *Glest* works in real time. It will make you think fast. There is no respite in *Glest*, which feels like work sometimes. Ah, but if only building magical creatures was work...

Glest is recommended for fantasy and medieval history buffs. You will also appreciate *Glest*'s decent 3D graphics and its quality animations, which are somewhat rare in GNU/Linux. And this game is not only stable, but also fast. A disclaimer: *Glest* reduces your screen resolution to 1024x768. So reset the resolution every time you quit the game. But what's a minor irritant like that when it comes with so much entertainment?

This game's on-board tutorials will teach you the game in half an hour. Extensions and add-ons are on *Glest*'s website at [www.glest.wikia.com](#). Most big distributions carry the game in their software repositories; Ubuntu does. With 2 GB of RAM and a dual-core processor, the game is snappy.

More than the final results of playing this game, you enjoy the sensations of a world where magic exists and you communicate with fantastic creatures. And you won't have to use your imagination: instead, watch dragons in action on your screen. But